

Australia Daily Brief

Thursday, September 17, 2026

1,785 words · 7 min read

RE: Cook Islands US port talks · Fiji declares HIV emergency · Labor slashes migration caps · Veterans health cap scrapped · China aids Vanuatu recovery

ASX 200

8,732

-0.99%

AUD/USD

0.7112

-0.61%

NZX 50

13,757

+0.33%

NZD/USD

0.5734

-1.24%

IN THIS ISSUE [Top Stories](#) · [Overnight](#) · [Stat](#) · [AUKUS](#) · [Pacific](#) · [New Zealand](#) · [China-Pacific](#) · [Canberra](#) · [Markets](#) · [Documents](#) · [Upcoming](#) · [The Wire](#) · [Analysis](#)

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 US Ambassador **Jared Novelly** says a future American military presence at the Cook Islands' Penrhyn port project "is all being negotiated", as Washington, Wellington, and Rarotonga fund the *NZ\$101 million* upgrade.
- 2 Fiji has declared a national HIV emergency, with roughly one in 60 adults estimated to carry the virus, while ruling out mandatory testing despite the surge.
- 3 Home Affairs Minister **Tony Burke** has cut Australia's working holiday-maker caps to 45,000 for a second year and 5,000 for a third, as Canberra separately scraps a \$5,000 veterans' allied health cap.

• TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji declares national HIV emergency as cases surge

Fiji has declared a national HIV emergency, with surging drug use driving an epidemic in which *one in 60* adults is estimated to be living with the virus. The government has expanded free rapid testing and is giving clean needles to drug users, but the minister has ruled out mandatory testing. University of Canterbury senior lecturer **Jalal Mohammed** said Fiji has traditionally spent about 3 percent of GDP on health, against a World Health Organization recommendation of 5 percent, and now needs 6 to 7 percent.

per NYT Asia Pacific: "Fiji Declares a National Emergency as H.I.V. Cases Skyrocket" · also Reuters

US-CHINA-PACIFIC

US confirms military presence talks at Cook Islands port

US Ambassador to the Cook Islands **Jared Novelty** said American military use of a planned port upgrade on Penrhyn Island is "all being negotiated", while insisting the project "is not a [US] military base". The United States and New Zealand are jointly funding the *NZ\$101 million* upgrade at Omoka, near an airfield built by US troops in World War Two, with Washington contributing US\$50 million and Wellington NZ\$17.5 million. Cook Islands Prime Minister **Mark Brown**, New Zealand Foreign Minister **Winston Peters**, and US Deputy Secretary of State **Christopher Landau** announced the project on the margins of the Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting in Palau.

per RNZ Pacific: "US military presence at Cook Islands port 'being negotiated', ambassador says"

AU-POLITICS

Labor unveils migration overhaul, slashes backpacker numbers

Home Affairs Minister **Tony Burke** announced an overhaul of Australia's migration settings at the National Press Club, cutting the working holiday-maker cap for a second year to *45,000*, down from the 57,000 who qualified this year, and for a third year to 5,000, down from 31,000. Extensions will be allocated by ballot and require regional work, with priority for migrants holding construction and agriculture skills. Farming and tourism leaders called the cuts a "low blow" for regional workforces.

per SMH Federal Politics: "What are Labor's new migration rules for Australia?" · also ABC News: "Backpacker cuts slammed as 'low blow' for farming and tourism"

• OVERNIGHT

AU-POLITICS

Government scraps \$5,000 allied health cap for veterans · ABC News

The Albanese government has dropped a plan to cap veterans' allied health services, including physiotherapy and dentistry, at \$5,000 a year. Minister for Veterans' Affairs **Matt Keogh** said the threshold measure was "off the table" after consultation. The May budget showed the measure would have saved roughly *\$750 million* over three years; it drew criticism from the Coalition and veteran advocacy groups. Canberra will also apologise to LGBTQ veterans.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Iran's exiled crown prince accepts Coalition invitation to Australia · ABC News

Exiled former crown prince **Reza Pahlavi** accepted an invitation to visit Australia after a virtual meeting with 10 Coalition MPs and senators, including Opposition Leader **Angus Taylor** and Shadow Foreign Affairs Minister **Ted O'Brien**. Pahlavi told Radio National Breakfast he is "a bridge" to democratic elections rather than a candidate. Iran expert **Kylie Moore-Gilbert** said the Coalition strayed into "choppy territory". No date has been set.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

New Zealand and Samoan nationals charged over Vietnam murder · RNZ Pacific

Samoa Police and the Australian Federal Police charged a New Zealand national and a Samoan national, aged 31 and 33, with conspiracy to murder over the May shooting of an Australian citizen in Ho Chi Minh City. The offence carries a maximum penalty of life imprisonment under Samoa's Crimes Act. Both men appeared in a Samoan court on Wednesday and were granted conditional bail.

China's Foreign Ministry spokesman **Guo Jiakun** accused American technology executives of "fearmongering" and warned that "vicious competition will only disrupt the process of global AI governance", after Anthropic chief executive **Dario Amodei** said a Chinese lead in AI "would pose great danger for the United States and the world". Beijing aims to integrate AI into 90 percent of its economy by 2030. **Xi Jinping** meets **Donald Trump** in Washington next week.

• STAT OF THE DAY

NZ\$101 million

Cost of the Penrhyn Island port upgrade, Cook Islands

The United States is contributing US\$50 million and New Zealand NZ\$17.5 million to a port whose potential military use Washington says is under negotiation.

RNZ Pacific

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 1 · USSC

[USSC charts a narrowing age gap on AUKUS submarines](#)

The United States Studies Centre published a By the Numbers item arguing the age gap on AUKUS submarines is narrowing. It lands alongside the centre's Briefing Room podcast marking five years of the agreement, "AUKUS at five: Full steam ahead?"

• PACIFIC WIRE

VANUATU · RNZ PACIFIC

[Vanuatu seeks criminal charges over MV Matui sinking](#)

Vanuatu's Maritime Safety Authority is seeking criminal charges against the captain and owners of the MV Matui. Maritime Affairs commissioner **Less John Napuati** said Tui Shipping Agency, deregistered since June, was permitted to carry cargo only and was warned about personnel overflow on 10 September. Two deaths are confirmed and more than 30 people remain missing.

FIJI · RNZ PACIFIC

[Seven cocaine bars vanish from Suva High Court exhibit room](#)

Fiji Police are investigating how seven cocaine bars disappeared from among 39 exhibits stored at the Suva High Court, found missing in a Tuesday inspection. Assistant commissioner (crime) **Loraini Seru** said the check was conducted before senior judiciary and prosecution officials. The Australian Federal Police reported 17 tonnes of illicit drugs seized across the Pacific since January, more than three times the 2025 total.

TUVALU · ABC PACIFIC

[Tuvalu presses Australia on fossil fuels before pre-COP31](#)

Tuvalu's climate minister **Maina Vakafua Talia** said he wants Australia to do more to ensure Pacific survival by stopping fossil fuel expansion. Tuvalu and Fiji co-host a pre-COP31 meeting in October, with global leaders set to visit Tuvalu for a special climate event. "We want to show some practical solutions," Talia said.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS (WIRE)

Fiji targets 24 December for new Constitution

Fiji is targeting 24 December for a new Constitution, the PacNews bulletin reports. The same bulletin carries Pacific ministers renewing their commitment to stronger, more integrated weather, climate, and early warning services, and reporting on young men topping male-to-male HIV cases in Fiji.

VANUATU · ISLANDS BUSINESS (WIRE)

Vanuatu bids to host Pacific Multi-Hazard Early Warning Centre

Vanuatu is seeking to host the Pacific Multi-Hazard Early Warning Centre, the PacNews bulletin reports. The same bulletin carries a law expert's warning that the Cook Islands port deal puts a focus on the military use of infrastructure in the Pacific, and reports a rising Pacific share of New Zealand overstayers.

MARSHALL ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS (WIRE)

'1.5C is not just a number for the Marshall Islands'

The PacNews bulletin carries the Marshall Islands framing 1.5C as more than a number, alongside Tuvalu's climate minister saying Pacific aid "doesn't really matter" next to Australia's fossil fuel subsidies, and reporting on Pacific communities strengthening homes ahead of cyclone season.

PALAU · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

Guam charter school eyes expansion into Palau and Chuuk

Career Tech High Academy Charter School in Guam has secured another six years of operations following charter renewal, with plans to expand to the Northern Mariana Islands, Palau, and Chuuk.

● NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · REUTERS

New Zealand GDP growth slows but tops forecasts

New Zealand's economy grew 0.2 percent in the second quarter, slower than the previous period but ahead of forecasts, in what Reuters described as a sign of resilience. Bloomberg also reported growth exceeded estimates. The result lands seven weeks before the general election on 7 November.

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · RNZ PACIFIC

Wellington issues Fiji travel advice after HIV emergency

The New Zealand government's SafeTravel website has warned travellers to Fiji to avoid activities that could increase infection risk following the emergency declaration. University of Canterbury senior health lecturer **Jalal Mohammed** said the declaration would not be a significant issue for most New Zealand travellers but offered a chance to reinforce basic health messaging.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

VANUATU · AID · ISLANDS BUSINESS (WIRE)

China donates NZ\$155,000 to Vanuatu recovery

Vanuatu has received NZ\$155,000, or *VT11 million*, from China to support recovery following volcanic activity on Ambae and a recent disaster. The tracker's last recorded PRC development for Vanuatu was 7 September, when the Pacific Islands Forum's China rebuke was buried in the communique.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Burke's eight words may hand opponents a campaign ad

The ABC's analysis argues Home Affairs Minister Tony Burke's migration address handed his political opponents material for a campaign advertisement. One Nation opened the week with its own immigration policy and the Coalition is still finalising its plan, leaving all three parties committed to cutting temporary migration by different means.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Brazil-based YouTuber uses AI accent to promote One Nation

A rising commentator posting daily videos favourable to One Nation is a Brazilian man whose Australian accent is AI generated, part of what researchers call a "slop" video economy built for cheap engagement. **Timothy Graham** of Queensland University of Technology and **David Hobson** of the Centre for Media, Technology and Democracy were cited.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Four 'major' terror plots since Bondi kept from the public

The Australian reports four major terror plots have been disrupted since the Bondi attack without public disclosure.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · ASPI STRATEGIST

Iron ore earnings projected to fall to \$77.2 billion

The government's June outlook projects iron ore export earnings falling from an estimated *A\$116.6 billion* in 2025-26 to *A\$77.2 billion*, in 2025-26 dollars, ASPI notes. Australia can remain indispensable to steelmaking while earning less from it.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Trump calls Canada's EU associate path a 'hostile act'

Donald Trump said allowing Canada to become an associate member of the European Union could be a hostile act. Canberra is weighing its own EU associate status after Brussels opened the door to Ottawa, as reported in this brief on September 15.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

COMMUNIQUE · PIF COMMUNIQUE

Forum says no member blocked China missile statement

The Pacific Islands Forum said no member blocked the statement on China's missile test, FBC News reported. The tracker records Nauru alone dissenting when the Forum closed with a joint statement on the test on 5

September.

READOUT · PIF COMMUNIQUE

Taipei Times: US backs Taiwan's participation in PIF

The Taipei Times reports American support for Taiwan's participation in the Pacific Islands Forum, following the United States backing Taiwan's continued role carried in this brief on September 16.

• UPCOMING

OCT
26

Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election

Begins the final phase of a campaign that will determine the next government's foreign and defence settings.

OCT
2026

Tuvalu and Fiji co-host pre-COP31 meeting, with a leaders' climate event in Tuvalu

Sets the Pacific negotiating position on fossil fuel expansion before COP31.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Decides whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues, with Winston Peters holding the foreign affairs portfolio.

• THE WIRE

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

"Fit for our times": Australia's International Development Policy three years on

Cameron Hill, a Research Fellow at the Development Policy Centre, revisits the purpose, priorities, and "plumbing" of Australia's International Development Policy three years after its release. The research was supported by the Gates Foundation.

LOWY INTERPRETER

Canberra will be a proving ground for Liu Jinsong's promotion path

Half of China's recent ambassadors to Canberra went on to vice-ministerial rank, the Interpreter notes, making the odds for the new envoy look good.

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

Fault Lines: defence bills, warning flares, Pacific cheques

ASPI's fortnightly Defence Strategy Program survey covers 4 to 17 September, taking in Japan, the Pacific Islands Forum, the Philippines, Solomon Islands, South Korea, and defence spending.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

RNZ PACIFIC

Taboo and underfunding behind Fiji's HIV crisis, lecturer says

Jalal Mohammed of the University of Canterbury said gaps in sexual health knowledge, health worker migration, multiple natural disasters, and Fiji's position on the "drug highway" contributed to a once-in-a-generation health crisis.

ABC NEWS

Former South Australian MP avoids jail over allowance fraud

Former South Australian MP **Fraser Ellis** avoided jail for deliberately rorting a parliamentary allowance, maintaining his actions showed "casualness" or "recklessness" and "certainly not criminality".

• ANALYSIS AND OPINION

LOWY INTERPRETER

The trade climate has already changed: Canberra is still adjusting too slowly

The Interpreter argues Australia's trade diversification effort lags the pace of global protectionism, which the piece says has reached record levels.

Argument: Global protectionism has hit record highs and Australia's diversification push has not caught up.

LOWY INTERPRETER

How Australia and Brazil could set the terms on critical minerals

The piece identifies an opening for producer coordination between Canberra and Brasilia while manufacturing economies chase supply certainty in critical minerals.

Argument: Australia and Brazil share interests as producers with vast reserves and could leverage them as manufacturing economies compete for supply certainty.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

[Read online](#)

[Past issues](#)

You are receiving the Australia Daily Brief as a member of the CSIS Australia Chair distribution list.

This newsletter is automatically generated, so it may contain errors. Please check all information and sources before citing. To report errors or other issues, please contact Andy Lim at alim@csis.org.

generated 6:11 AM ET

[↑ BACK TO TOP](#)